

Who Held the Seat, and Who Won the Election

A roster is not a return, and the gap between them is 2,344 people

84-355 Democracy’s Data

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This part is called the record of an outcome, and most of it earns the name: certified county returns, precinct returns, the ballots themselves. Each one records a **contest** – on one day, in one place, these people got these votes.

Four chapters in this part do not use returns at all. `midterm-loss` counts seats each party held. `retirements` and `careers` follow members in and out of office. `primary-defeats` asks which incumbents were denied renomination. What they run on is a **roster**: a list of who was a member of Congress, and when.

A roster and a return look interchangeable, and they are not. This chapter is about the difference, which is measurable.

01 A return records a contest; a roster records a membership

Roster	Published by	One row is	Answers
Membership roster	Voteview (academic, from official sources)	One member in one Congress	Who was seated, and when
Party divisions	Office of the Historian, U.S. House	One Congress	How many seats each party held
Candidate returns	Federal Election Commission	One candidate in one election	Who ran, and how many votes they got

The returns chapter built this part on a single limit: a return is complete, official, and **permanently silent about who voted**. The ballot is secret, so no return links a vote to a voter.

A roster has the mirror-image limit, and it is easy to miss because it points the other way. **A roster is silent about votes**. It will tell you exactly who sat in the 47th Congress and for how long, and it does not contain a single ballot. The `party-divisions` series that `midterm-loss` runs on is the clean case: 0 of its columns carry a vote total. It counts seats.

That is a fair trade as long as seats and elections correspond. Mostly they do.

Before you read on, commit to a number. Across 118 Congresses there have been 38,088 seat-terms to fill. **How many different people do you think have filled them?** The same number? A few dozen more? Write it down.

02 More people than there are seats

Congress	Year	Members	Seats	Excess	Deaths in office
14	1815	199	140	59	5
16	1819	201	143	58	3
13	1813	196	141	55	2
23	1833	258	204	54	5
73	1933	447	393	54	13
15	1817	195	142	53	2
27	1841	259	207	52	10
17	1821	201	150	51	4

Across 118 Congresses, **40,432 people have served in 38,088 seats** — an excess of **2,344**, or 6.2% more people than there were seats for. The worst single case is the 14th (1815) Congress, which seated 199 members in 140 seats.

Every one of those 2,344 arrived **mid-Congress**, and that is not an approximation — it is the same number counted a second way, which the build asserts rather than assumes. They were appointed, or won a special election, or were seated once a contested result was resolved. **No general election for that Congress put them there.** 744 of the vacancies they filled were created by a death in office.

This is the practical consequence: a file of general-election returns, however complete, cannot account for 6.2% of the people who have held a seat in the House. Ask a returns file who represented a district in 1815 and it will give you the person who won the election, which in 14th (1815) was frequently not the person doing the job.

03 Most departures are not decided by voters

The gap runs the other way too. Ask why a member stopped serving, and the election explains less than you would expect.

Outcome	Members	Decided by a voter
re-elected	3,653	—
did not seek re-election	387	no
defeated in the general election	225	yes
ran for the Senate	102	no

Outcome	Members	Decided by a voter
denied renomination	58	yes
died in office	18	no

Over the 10 most recent Congresses, 790 members stopped serving. A voter decided **283** of those departures — losing a general election, or being denied renomination in a primary. The other **507**, or **64.2%**, were not decided by any voter at all: the member retired, ran for the Senate, or died.

Roughly two thirds of the turnover in the House is not an electoral event. That is a fact about the institution which no return can report. It is exactly the fact that `retirements` and `careers` exist to study.

04 What a roster can settle that a return cannot

The point is not that rosters are inferior. They answer questions returns cannot touch.

A return is a snapshot of one day. A roster is a **duration**, and duration is what a career is made of. Of 13,320 careers in the file, **1,175 are not one continuous stretch**, or 8.8% of them. The member left and came back. A returns file records each of those wins separately and has no way to know they belong to the same person's career.

A roster is also the only way to answer *who was actually in the room*. Whether a bill passed depends on who held the seat that week, not on who won the election two years earlier. That is why the roll-call chapters in Part IV begin from a membership file rather than from returns.

05 What this chapter cannot tell you

It cannot tell you why anyone left. The outcome column is a classification built from what the file records — appeared on a ballot, did not, died. A retirement that was really a pre-emption of certain defeat is recorded as a retirement, because that is all the roster knows.

It cannot reconcile the two kinds of file for you. Matching a roster to a returns file is its own problem, and `primary-defeats` is where it is done. That chapter matches 3,936 incumbent-primary rows to members by name and district, and reports the failures rather than dropping them.

It cannot be extended backwards indefinitely. The membership series runs across 118 Congresses; the departure classification depends on candidate filings and runs over 10. The two-thirds finding is a modern one, and this chapter does not claim it held in 1815.

And it cannot tell you who the voters wanted. That is the returns file's question, and the point of putting the two beside each other is that neither one answers both.

06 Sources

Nothing in this chapter was downloaded. Every figure is read from the derived tables four other chapters already built:

- `retirements — departures.csv`, `exits.csv`. Members and seats by Congress, and why each member stopped serving.
- `careers — careers.csv`. One row per career, with the gaps.
- `midterm-loss — house_midterms.csv`. Party divisions by election.
- `primary-defeats — incumbents.csv`. Incumbents facing a primary, matched to the roster.

Three files sit underneath them, and each is published free of charge: Voteview's membership file (<https://voteview.com/>), the Office of the Historian's Party Divisions tables (<https://history.house.gov/Institution/Party-Divisions/Party-Divisions/>) and the Federal Election Commission's *Federal Elections* compendium (<https://www.fec.gov/introduction-campaign-finance/election-results-and-voting-information/>). The four chapters above document what each one cost to get and what it left out; this chapter's subject is what the three have in common.

Every figure above is recomputed from those tables, and checked against the values asserted in `checks.csv`. The table is printed here verbatim.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`careers.csv`, `excess.csv`, `exits.csv`, `rosters.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `excess.csv` shows more members than seats in almost every Congress, with `mid_congress` and `died` beside it. Follow `excess` across the series. Is the churn falling?
- `exits.csv` flags whether each departure was `voter_decided`. Work out what share of exits the voters actually chose. Does that match how congressional turnover is usually described?
- `rosters.csv` says what each source `answers` and what it is `silent_about`. Pick a question you would want answered and decide whether any roster can settle it.
- A roster and a return disagree about how many people held a seat. Using `excess.csv`, work out where the extra people come from.

Check	Value
Rosters described	3
Chapters read, none of them downloaded	4
Congresses in the membership series	118
People who have served in the House	40,432
Seats that have existed to serve in	38,088

Check	Value
Excess of people over seats	2,344
Excess as a share of seats, %	6.2
Mid-Congress arrivals (identical to the excess, by construction)	2,344
Seats emptied by a death in office	744
Worst single Congress: members	199
Worst single Congress: seats	140
Worst single Congress: which, and when	14th (1815)
Congresses in the modern exit file	10
Departures in that file	790
Departures a voter decided	283
Departures no voter decided	507
Share no voter decided, %	64.2
Careers in the career file	13,320
Careers that are not one continuous interval	1,175
Columns in the party-divisions series carrying a vote total	0
Incumbent-primary rows available for matching	3,936
